



TRAPPED AND KILLED



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It was in a patch of mangrove forest in Mullaitivu district where the cornered LTTE chief died fighting.

A PHOTO OF PRABHAKARAN'S BODY RELEASED BY THE LANKAN ARMY

AP Photo/SRI LANKA ARMY VIA AP/TN HO

previous day, government sources had indicated that all the top leaders including Prabhakaran had been killed in a final assault in a lagoon near Mullaitivu town. There was talk of how he had tried to escape in an ambulance along with three deputies and a rocket strike on the vehicle had charred their bodies beyond recognition. But in the evening when an LTTE leader based in the Far East claimed Prabhakaran was alive, the media was agog with speculation.

Army Chief Sarath Fonseka told INDIA TODAY that he had got a call from his commander just after the President's address in Parliament informing him that they had recovered the body of Prabhakaran and that identification was positive. So he went on

RAJCHENGAPPA



national television and formally announced the death of the Tiger chief. But as in the case of Che Guevara, the Latin American revolutionary, the Sri Lankan Government was forced to produce further proof. So the Sri Lankan Army released photographs and videos of Prabhakaran's body in battle fatigues with a gunshot wound over an eyebrow and the top of his scalp completely blown away. Doubts were again raised as to whether it was Prabhakaran's double that had been found and jokes cracked that morticians in Colombo would soon go out of business with the army becoming an expert in the art of dressing up bodies. So the army sent out Karuna, Prabhakaran's former lieutenant who had defected years earlier, and a re-

Our motherland has been freed from terrorism. But we do not regard the military solution as a final one for the Tamils. MAHINDA RAJAPAKSE, President, Sri Lanka

